

Lesson One: An Introduction to Koran and Classical Arabic

Wheeler M. Thackston

The Arabic Definite Article

The Arabic definite article is **alif-lam** (ال), which is the exact equivalent of the English word “the”.

Key Characteristics:

- **Always attached directly** to the noun (it is never written as a separate word).
- **Invariable**: It never changes its form based on the gender or number of the noun it modifies.

The 28 letters of the Arabic alphabet are divided evenly into two groups of 14 letters each based on how they phonetically interact with the definite article: **Moon Letters** (Non-Assimilating) and **Sun Letters** (Assimilating).

The Alphabet

Name of Letter	Alone Form	Transcription
*'alif	ا	—
bā'	ب	b
tā'	ت	t
ṭā'	ث	θ
jīm	ج	j
ḥā'	ح	ḥ
xā	خ	x
*dāl	د	d
*ḏāl	ذ	ḏ
*rā'	ر	r
*zāy	ز	z
sīn	س	s
šīn	ش	š
ṣād	ص	ṣ
ḍād	ض	ḍ
ṭā'	ط	ṭ
ẓā'	ظ	ẓ
‘ayn	ع	‘
ğayn	غ	ğ
fā'	ف	f
qāf	ق	q
kāf	ك	k
lām	ل	l
mīm	م	m
nūn	ن	n
hā'	ه	h
*wāw	و	w
yā'	ي	y

1. Moon Letters (Non-Assimilating) — 14 Letters

When the definite article precedes a Moon Letter, the *lām* (l) sound is fully and explicitly pronounced (*al-*).

#	Arabic	Name	Trans.	Article	Example	Meaning
1	أ	*'alif	—	al-	الأرض (<i>al-'arḍu</i>)	the earth
2	ب	bā'	b	al-	البيت (<i>al-baytu</i>)	the house
3	ج	jīm	j	al-	الجنة (<i>al-jannatu</i>)	paradise
4	ح	ḥā'	ḥ	al-	الحليم (<i>al-ḥalīmu</i>)	the forbearing
5	خ	xā	x	al-	الخبر (<i>al-xabaru</i>)	the news
6	ع	‘ayn	‘	al-	العالم (<i>al-'ālamu</i>)	the world
7	غ	ğayn	ğ	al-	الغيب (<i>al-ğaybu</i>)	the unseen
8	ف	fā'	f	al-	الفجر (<i>al-fajru</i>)	the dawn
9	ق	qāf	q	al-	القلب (<i>al-qalbu</i>)	the heart
10	ك	kāf	k	al-	الكتاب (<i>al-kitābu</i>)	the book
11	م	mīm	m	al-	الماء (<i>al-mā'u</i>)	the water
12	ه	hā'	h	al-	الهواء (<i>al-hawā'u</i>)	the air
13	و	*wāw	w	al-	الوقت (<i>al-waqtu</i>)	the time
14	ي	yā'	y	al-	اليوم (<i>al-yawmu</i>)	the day

2. Sun Letters (Assimilating) — 14 Letters

When the definite article precedes a Sun Letter, the *lām* sound is assimilated into the following letter, causing that letter to double phonetically (marked with a *shaddah* in script).

#	Arabic	Name	Trans.	Article	Example	Meaning
1	ت	tāʾ	t	at-	التين (<i>at-tīnu</i>)	the fig
2	ث	θāʾ	θ	aθ-	الثلج (<i>aθ-θalju</i>)	the snow
3	د	*dāl	d	ad-	الدين (<i>ad-dīnu</i>)	the religion
4	ذ	*ḏāl	ḏ	aḏ-	الذهب (<i>aḏ-ḏahabu</i>)	the gold
5	ر	*rāʾ	r	ar-	الرجل (<i>ar-rajulu</i>)	the man
6	ز	*zāy	z	az-	الزمان (<i>az-zamānu</i>)	the time
7	س	sīn	s	as-	السماء (<i>as-samāʾu</i>)	the sky
8	ش	šīn	š	aš-	الشمس (<i>aš-šamsu</i>)	the sun
9	ص	ṣād	ṣ	aṣ-	الصبر (<i>aṣ-ṣabru</i>)	the patience
10	ض	ḏād	ḏ	aḏ-	الضوء (<i>aḏ-ḏawʾu</i>)	the light
11	ط	ṭāʾ	ṭ	aṭ-	الطريق (<i>aṭ-ṭarīqu</i>)	the road
12	ظ	ẓāʾ	ẓ	az-	الظلم (<i>aẓ-target</i>)	the injustice
13	ل	lām	l	al-	الليل (<i>al-laylu</i>)	the night
14	ن	nūn	n	an-	النجم (<i>an-najmu</i>)	the star